

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Nail Technician English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Nail technicians, manicurists, pedicurists, and nail-salon reception staff.

All scenarios, prices, products, records, and incidents are fictional language practice. This is not instruction in nail preparation, application, removal, disinfection, chemical handling, or medical assessment. Qualified staff must determine service suitability and follow current product instructions and local requirements. Do not diagnose nail or skin conditions from these exercises.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

accent nail

A nail given a different decorative design to stand out from the others.

almond shape

A nail outline that narrows toward a softly pointed, almond-like tip.

booking deposit

Money paid in advance toward an appointment under the salon's stated terms.

chip

A small piece missing from the edge or surface of a nail coating.

consultation

A discussion to clarify preferences, relevant history, and the proposed nail service before agreement.

contact time

The period a disinfectant must remain in contact as specified by its label and applicable procedure.

cuticle

The thin layer of nonliving tissue attached to the nail plate near its base; not the whole surrounding skin.

disinfection

A specified process to reduce or eliminate relevant microorganisms on suitable objects; not the same as tidying.

embellishment

A decorative addition, such as a small ornament, included in a nail design.

extension

An artificial addition that lengthens the nail beyond its natural length.

free edge

The part of a natural nail that extends beyond the fingertip.

gel polish

A nail coating designed to cure under a compatible lamp according to its product system.

infill

A maintenance service addressing the grown-out area of an existing enhancement when suitable.

lacquer

Conventional nail polish that forms a colored coating as it dries.

lifting

Separation of an applied nail enhancement or coating from the natural nail.

manicure

A cosmetic service for fingernails and hands, with the included elements set by the salon menu.

matte

Having a low-shine appearance rather than a glossy surface.

nail art

Decorative patterns or images created on nails.

nail plate

The hard, visible part of the natural nail.

overlay

An enhancement product applied over the natural nail without deliberately adding length.

pedicure

A cosmetic service for toenails and feet, not medical treatment of foot conditions.

removal appointment

A visit booked to assess and remove an existing nail product using the appropriate professional service.

repair appointment

A visit reserved to assess and, when suitable and agreed, correct a specific nail-service problem.

reusable implement

A nail-service tool intended for repeated use subject to required cleaning and disinfection.

service quote

A stated price for a specified nail service before the client agrees to it.

service record

The salon's factual record of the service, selected products, and relevant client discussion.

sheer

Allowing some of the underlying nail to remain visible through the color.

single-use item

A service item intended for one use rather than reuse on another client.

snag

An uneven edge that catches on clothing or another surface.

squoval

A nail outline combining a relatively square end with softened corners.

swatch

A sample showing a nail color or finish for comparison.

tenderness

Soreness or discomfort reported when an area is touched or pressed.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Check length before interpreting a service label

Do you want added length or ___?

Which part of the photo do you mean?

Your booking says ___; let's confirm ___.

Terms such as full set can be used loosely. Ask about added length explicitly rather than treating a photograph as a complete instruction.

Word combinations in this lesson

retain the natural length: keep the client's current nail length

clarify the booked service: check which service the appointment reserves

add extra length: make the finished nail longer than the natural nail

describe the desired result: explain the appearance wanted before choosing a service

Compare like-for-like features

This outline is ___, whereas that one is ___.

The lengths differ as well as ___.

Which feature matters most for ___?

Two samples can differ on more than one dimension. Name the outline and length separately so a preference for one does not silently select the other.

Word combinations in this lesson

soften the corners: describe a less sharply squared outline

compare the silhouettes: look at the outer shapes side by side

keep a practical length: choose a length suited to the client's stated activities

point to the free edge: identify the part extending beyond the fingertip

Explain two different appearance choices

Matte describes ___; sheer describes ___.

You can prefer ___ without requesting ___.

The product choice is still ___.

A color name does not specify coverage, finish, or product system. Explain each choice using the client's actual description.

Word combinations in this lesson

choose a finish: select the intended shiny or low-shine appearance

compare the coverage: discuss how much of the nail remains visible

check the product label: identify the exact product rather than guess from its color

describe a sheer shade: explain that the underlying nail remains partly visible

Offer a design tradeoff with a clear total

The charge is ___ per nail.

With ___ accent nails, the total is ___.

Which ___ nails would you choose?

State whether a charge applies per nail, per hand, or to the whole design. Confirm the selected nails as well as the total.

Word combinations in this lesson

price per nail: state a charge for each decorated nail

simplify the design: reduce its decorative detail

confirm the design count: agree how many nails receive the pattern

stay within the budget: choose work that fits the stated spending limit

State a service boundary without diagnosing

You've reported ____; the cause is unknown.

I can't confirm that ____ is appropriate.

Let's pause the request while ____.

Use the client's own symptom words. Distinguish a reported feeling, an observed change, and an unknown cause. Refer the health concern to an appropriate healthcare professional; salon staff separately decide whether the cosmetic service is suitable without diagnosing the cause.

Word combinations in this lesson

describe the location: identify where a concern is felt or seen

pause on request: stop the activity when the client asks

avoid diagnosing the cause: do not label an unassessed condition as a medical finding

refer a health concern: direct a medical question to an appropriate healthcare professional

Describe the stage, not an impression

____ is tidy; ____ remains incomplete.

____ has been confirmed ready.

I don't yet have a reliable estimate for ____.

Give a concise status and a verified alternative. Do not turn this language exercise into instructions for disinfectant use or tool preparation.

Word combinations in this lesson

confirm station readiness: check whether the required preparation is complete

separate used items: distinguish used items from those prepared for a service

check the readiness record: consult the salon's recorded preparation status

give a waiting-time update: tell a client what is complete and what remains uncertain

Repair a specific mismatch

The note says ____; the result shows ____.

I'm sorry we missed ____.

The review covers ____; it doesn't yet confirm ____.

Separate the confirmed mismatch from the remedy, which may still require assessment and agreement.

Word combinations in this lesson

report a chipped edge: describe the missing coating and its location

review the service record: check what was actually recorded at the earlier visit

acknowledge a design mismatch: recognize that the result differs from the discussed design

confirm review terms: explain any stated review fee and what the appointment covers

Pass on what remains undecided

The client requested ____; it isn't booked yet.

The existing product is ____.

Please confirm ____ before offering ____.

State the existing product as unknown rather than guessing its identity. Pass the actual next task to the receiving colleague.

Word combinations in this lesson

allow time for removal: include a separate removal requirement in scheduling

confirm the existing product: identify what is already on the nails

carry over a preference: preserve a confirmed choice for the next worker to check

read back the booking: repeat the date, time, service, and unresolved details

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Clarifying the service and the intended length

A client booked an overlay but calls it a full set and points to a long reference image. They actually want to keep their current short length. No work has begun. Clarify length and explain why the image does not automatically mean extensions.

You've booked an overlay, and you said you want to keep your current short length. The photograph shows added length, so let's separate its color from its shape. Are you asking for the pictured color on your existing length, or do you want extensions?

Try it again: The client says overlay and extension sound interchangeable. Explain the length distinction plainly.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Comparing shape and practical length

A client likes a long almond sample but needs a short result for keyboard work. A short squoval sample is also available. Compare the sample silhouettes and lengths without promising that either shape will prevent breakage or discomfort.

The almond sample narrows toward the tip, whereas this short squoval sample has a flatter end with softer corners. Their lengths differ too, so shape alone isn't the comparison. Since you prefer a short result for keyboard work, let's discuss the shorter reference before deciding what suits your nails.

Try it again: The client assumes selecting the short sample guarantees it will never snag. Avoid an unsupported promise.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Explaining color, coverage, and finish

A client requests matte pink but selects a sheer glossy swatch. They want a low-shine appearance with the nail line still visible. The booking does not specify lacquer or gel polish. Explain finish versus coverage and leave product selection open.

Matte describes the low-shine finish, whereas sheer describes how much of your nail remains visible. You want a sheer pink with less shine, not necessarily an opaque color. This swatch is glossy, so it doesn't show both preferences. We still need to discuss the product choice separately.

Try it again: The client thinks a glossy swatch proves a matte version will be identical apart from shine. Offer comparison without guaranteeing an exact match.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Agreeing on nail art and a complete quote

A fictional base service costs \$30. Simple line art is \$5 per nail, with no other charges in this exercise. The client wants four decorated nails but has a \$40 limit. Offer two decorated nails for \$40 or the base service alone for \$30.

The base service is thirty dollars, and the line art is five dollars per nail. Four decorated nails would total fifty, above your forty-dollar limit. Two accent nails would bring the total to forty. Would you prefer those two, or the thirty-dollar base service without the design?

Try it again: The client requests an embellishment not included in the line-art quote. Keep its price unconfirmed.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Responding to discomfort and uncertain nail concerns

Before any service starts, a client reports unexplained tenderness beside one nail and asks you to cover it with product for an event. Pause that service request and refer the health concern to an appropriate healthcare professional without diagnosing or suggesting treatment. Explain that the salon must separately decide whether the cosmetic service is suitable; referral does not promise service approval.

I understand you want the nail to look finished for the event. You've reported unexplained tenderness, so let's pause this request and refer the health concern to an appropriate healthcare professional. I can't diagnose its cause. The salon must separately assess whether the cosmetic service is suitable; the referral doesn't guarantee that we'll proceed.

Try it again: The client says a friend called it harmless. Acknowledge the report without adopting that conclusion.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Giving a clear station-readiness update

Station three is tidy, but its required readiness checks are incomplete. Station two has been confirmed ready by the responsible technician. A client is waiting. Offer station two without calling station three ready or providing disinfection instructions.

Station three is tidy, but its required readiness checks are not complete. Station two has been confirmed ready, so we can offer that space instead. If you prefer station three, I can update you when its status is confirmed, but I don't have a reliable waiting estimate yet.

Try it again: The client asks for a specific waiting time nobody has confirmed. Offer the verified alternative without inventing minutes.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Handling a chip or design concern

A client requested line art facing them, but the finished lettering faces away. The service record confirms the client's original direction. A review is available today at four with no review fee. Do not promise a particular correction before assessment.

Our service note says the lettering should face you, and the current direction doesn't match that request. I'm sorry we missed that detail. We can review it today at four without a review fee. We'll discuss the suitable correction and any terms before you decide, rather than assume a particular remedy.

Try it again: The client interprets a free review as a promise of a free full new set. Clarify what has actually been offered.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Scheduling follow-up and handing over exact requests

A client requested plain color next Friday at ten but also reports an unidentified existing product. Reception must arrange a consultation before confirming removal time or an infill. The client declines nail art. Friday is a requested time, not yet booked.

The client wants plain color next Friday at ten and has declined nail art. They report an existing product but cannot identify it, so removal time and any infill suitability remain unconfirmed. Please arrange a consultation and check availability. Friday at ten is their request, not a confirmed appointment.

Try it again: The client finds a receipt with only a color name. Explain why the product identity remains open.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Manicurists and Pedicurists

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/personal-care-and-service/manicurists-and-pedicurists.htm>

OSHA: Health Hazards in Nail Salons

<https://www.osha.gov/nail-salons>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Nail Technician English

Professional audience: Nail technicians, manicurists, pedicurists, and nail-salon reception staff

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Lesson 01: Clarifying the service and the intended length

Original fictional case: A client booked an overlay but calls it a full set and points to a long reference image. They actually want to keep their current short length. No work has begun. Clarify length and explain why the image does not automatically mean extensions.

Language workshop: Check length before interpreting a service label

Communication goal: Distinguish a client's visual preference from a booking name.

Language guidance: Terms such as full set can be used loosely. Ask about added length explicitly rather than treating a photograph as a complete instruction.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Do you want added length or ___? / Which part of the photo do you mean? / Your booking says ___; let's confirm ___.

Vocabulary: manicure: A cosmetic service for fingernails and hands, with the included elements set by the salon menu. / pedicure: A cosmetic service for toenails and feet, not medical treatment of foot conditions. / overlay: An enhancement product applied over the natural nail without deliberately adding length. / extension: An artificial addition that lengthens the nail beyond its natural length.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: want the pictured pink color but no additional length; used full set without a precise meaning.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: The client says overlay and extension sound interchangeable. Explain the length distinction plainly.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: You've booked an overlay, and you said you want to keep your current short length. The photograph shows added length, so let's separate its color from its shape. Are you asking for the pictured color on your existing length, or do you want extensions?

END REFERENCE

TASK: Retrieve occupational vocabulary

1. Select four terms from the reference. Explain each in plain English, give two natural collocations and quote or create a short workplace example. Label invented examples. Contrast each term with a plausible confusable term; acknowledge regional variation.
2. Present one role-labelled exchange with one missing word or phrase and four choices A-D. Exactly one choice must fit the stated facts and grammar. Stop and wait for my answer before revealing it.
3. Explain all four options, then invite me to read the completed exchange aloud. Offer a sentence frame for optional spoken practice, never an open-ended writing assignment.
4. Repeat for the other three terms, one question at a time. Vary the correct letter and the situation; preserve the reference facts. If a choice is ambiguous, replace the item.
5. Finish with two new four-choice collocation questions for later review, with a clearly separate answer key. Do not claim to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT